

WHAT HE LEFT BEHIND

***DENOTES POWER POINT SLIDE**

****DENOTES INSTRUCTION TO THE
TECHNICIAN**

TEXT: Acts 1:9-10 (KJV) *“And when he had spoken these things, while they beheld, he was taken up; and a cloud received him out of their sight. And while they looked stedfastly toward heaven as he went up, behold, two men stood by them in white apparel; Which also said, Ye men of Galilee, why stand ye gazing up into heaven? This same Jesus, which is taken up from you into heaven, shall so come in like manner as ye have seen him go into heaven.”*

INTRO: If I could have only been there to have watched a crucified but resurrected Jesus leave earth from Bethany's launching pad! What a pleasure it would have been to stand on the mountain with the other five hundred believers! To have rubbed shoulders with the apostles, and to have watched as Jesus was received up into Glory, as the angels replaced Him as messengers of encouragement! What a sight it must have been!

I'm sure to those standing there it was a very ambivalent sight; they were no doubt thrilled to be part of such an historic and heavenly moment; yet, they were saddened by His exit!

He did not choose to keep His ascension a secret, in fact, for three and one half years His death, burial, resurrection and ascension had been a theme of His ministry! After all Jesus had told the disciples of His departure again and again. I am not sure they ever expected this day to come as quickly as it did, and I am certainly not convinced they thought it would happen in this way!

Though the crowd of people who were gathered at Bethany's launching pad was probably astounded at the power and anointing of the moment, it was not long until reality set in; He is gone; Jesus is gone; He is really gone!

They no doubt thought that when He told them He would have to go away, it was just a metaphor or parable. I don't believe they thought it would literally happen; surely Jesus was speaking in jest for He would almost certainly not leave this infant church alone! Would He? They were not ready for the responsibility and probably felt ill equipped.

Just a few days before this epic event, the apparent leaders were fighting among themselves to decide who would have the loftiest positions in His Kingdom. When they were called upon to take a public stand displaying stability, they went into denial and hiding, fearing for their very lives. Surely this crowd gathered at Bethany was not the type of leadership Jesus would leave in charge of His infant Church!

Notice the backdrop of this story: **(LLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Chaos was still the norm in Jerusalem...
- Most of the public did not believe Jesus had risen from the dead...
- The political and religious leaders were determined to quell what they felt were rumors of a risen Jesus...
- The explanation of an empty tomb by political and religious leaders was that the disciples of Jesus had stolen His body from the tomb...

Most of the people present at Bethany's launching pad that day felt they could very well be arrested at any time. They still looked behind their backs and watched the Roman soldiers as they roamed the streets. The past few days were horrifying to them from the standpoint of Roman law and Jewish customs.

Every day the disciples left home, they did not know if they would make it back safely that night. Their anxieties and worries were complicated by the fact that they had been a part of the ministry of Jesus for the better part of four years. They were easily identifiable, the public knew who they were and where they lived and you can bet the Roman government documented their every move.

Just when it seemed that things could not be in a worse state, He was gone, Jesus was gone!

Following the events at Bethany, the next morning they went to the mountain to see if He would return. Wouldn't you know it, nothing but blue sky and white fluffy clouds were gathered in the sky! The angel said He would be coming back just like He went away! Where was He? How were they going to make it? When could they expect His return?

He had talked about giving gifts and leaving promises, but they had not experienced anything like this, so their minds were fuzzy and puzzled about the future. The reality of the moment began to set in on them, He's gone!

But what was that He told them to do just before He left? Go back to Jerusalem and pray for the promise of the Father? What was that all about? Just what was going on with this bedraggled, disheveled, unnerved group of disciples who had been with Jesus for the past three and a half years?

Just like the disciples, our Lord is no longer physically among us, He's gone and has been gone from this earth for more than 2,000 years, but just look what **He left behind!** **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- An unfinished task...
- An unchallengeable message...
- An unquestionable love...
- An unmerited grace...
- An unstoppable force...
- An unfailing promise...

I. AN UNFINISHED TASK...

Jesus had told the disciples, *“The Son of man is come to seek and to save that which was lost.”* This is the bedrock of hope for everyone here today! We were *“That which was lost.”* Over a two thousand year period untold millions have come to know Christ as their personal Savior but as long as there is one person not saved, the task is not complete.

The song writer was right when he penned the words, *“Though millions have come, there’s still room for one; there’s room at the cross for you.”*

As long as there are people who have not heard the message of the gospel of Christ, the task is not complete; the work of the church is not done; He left behind an unfinished job for the church.

Jesus left behind parting instructions for a church with an incomplete task when He said, *“Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost, teaching them to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you; and lo, I am with you alway, even unto the end of the world. Amen.”*

The task is incomplete, He wants the job finished and it is not! **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- The mission fields cry out “unfinished”...
- The cities and towns cry out “unfinished”...
- The downtrodden cry out “unfinished”...
- The up and coming cry out “unfinished”...

- The ghettos cry out “unfinished”
- The lonely cry out “unfinished”...
- The sin-sick cry out “unfinished”...
- Our neighbors cry out “unfinished”...
- Our unsaved family members cry out “unfinished”...
- Our world cries out “unfinished”...

There is still a call that comes ringing over the restless waves, *“Send the light! Send the light! There are souls to rescue, there are souls to save, send the light!”*

Jesus left a task unfinished which He instructed the church to fulfill, and it is still there for you and I to finish. And do it we must if we are going to fulfill His request.

Think of this, if twelve people would commit to winning one person per year and making that convert into a disciple who brings a person a year to Christ, over a twenty year period, 12,582,900 people would be won to the Lord! In the world of the disciples, if the command of Jesus had been carried out by twelve men over a forty year period the population of the planet would have been converted.

Isak Dinesen said, *“When you have a great and difficult task, something perhaps almost impossible, if you only work a little at a time, every day a little, suddenly the work will finish itself.”* **(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)**

He's gone, but he left behind an unfinished task! Who among us will step up to the plate and become actively involved in finishing the task of taking this gospel to the ends of the earth?

II. AN UNCHALLENGEABLE MESSAGE...

Acts 1:1-3 (NKJV) *"The former account I made, O Theophilus, of all that Jesus began both to do and teach, ²until the day in which He was taken up, after He through the Holy Spirit had given commandments to the apostles whom He had chosen, ³to whom He also presented Himself alive after His suffering by many infallible proofs, being seen by them during forty days and speaking of the things pertaining to the kingdom of God."*

The word infallible is a very strong word meaning *"Incapable of error; never wrong."* **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)** The word infallible can be interchanged with words like:

- Perfect...
- Reliable...
- Flawless...
- Surefire...

The writer is letting us know that Jesus left no doubt that He was alive from the dead and that His message, the message of the Bible, and that of the church are as secure as anything could ever be!

The gospel of Jesus Christ is marked by such things as:

(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Infallible proofs...
- Irrefutable examples...
- Indisputable facts...
- Unmistakable words...
- Undeniable doctrine...
- Unchallengeable message...

This gospel has been and is being attacked by the liberal element of our world. Men and women have attempted to destroy truth and establish other means of salvation acceptable to mankind. This never has, and never will work.

The real tragedy is that there are ministers and churches which have gone out of their way to dumb down the Gospel which Jesus died to establish, so that they can grow their church and make more people feel “Safe” within their four walls! **This Gospel is what it is, and no man has the authority to alter or change it!**

(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)

Man is ill-equipped to challenge this wonderful gospel of God. In fact, those who attempt to change its meaning place themselves under a curse! Galatians 1:6-10 (NKJV) *“I marvel that you are turning away so soon from Him who called you in the grace of Christ, to a different gospel, ⁷which is not another; but there are some who trouble you and want to pervert the gospel of Christ. ⁸But even if we, or an angel from heaven, preach any other gospel to you*

than what we have preached to you, let him be accursed.⁹ As we have said before, so now I say again, if anyone preaches any other gospel to you than what you have received, let him be accursed.¹⁰ For do I now persuade men, or God? Or do I seek to please men? For if I still pleased men, I would not be a bondservant of Christ.”

The devil has tried, but cannot effectively challenge or change this wonderful Gospel. Hebrews 4:12 (NKJV) *“For the word of God is living and powerful, and sharper than any two-edged sword, piercing even to the division of soul and spirit, and of joints and marrow, and is a discerner of the thoughts and intents of the heart.”* Someone said the Word of God will feed the sheep, skin the goats, de-horn the hypocrites, and cut the devils head completely off! Psalms 119:89-90 (NKJV) *“Forever, O LORD, Your word is settled in heaven.”⁹⁰ Your faithfulness endures to all generations; You established the earth, and it abides.”* At the end of time, John caught a glimpse of the Word in action! Revelation 14:6 (NKJV) *“Then I saw another angel flying in the midst of heaven, having the everlasting gospel to preach to those who dwell on the earth—to every nation, tribe, tongue, and people!”*

Listen to the words of Jesus! Luke 21:33 (KJV) *“Heaven and earth shall pass away: but my words shall not pass away.”*

We should all be warned that if we attempt to get in any other way than the way prescribed by this wonderful Book called the Bible, we are instructed that we will be viewed as a thief and a robber. John 10:1-5 (NKJV) ***“Most assuredly, I say to you, he who does not enter the sheepfold by the door, but climbs up some other way, the same is a thief and a robber.*** ²***“But he who enters by the door is the shepherd of the sheep.*** ³***“To him the doorkeeper opens, and the sheep hear his voice; and he calls his own sheep by name and leads them out.*** ⁴***“And when he brings out his own sheep, he goes before them; and the sheep follow him, for they know his voice.*** ⁵***“Yet they will by no means follow a stranger, but will flee from him, for they do not know the voice of strangers.”***

He left us a wonderful message to accept and believe.
What is the message that cannot be changed?
(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- God created the world...
- God created man...
- Man sinned...
- God sent a sacrifice in Jesus...
- Jesus was born of a virgin...
- Jesus lived a sinless life...
- Jesus died on a cross for sin...
- His blood sacrifice is the only way to God...
- Jesus rose from the dead on the third day...
- Jesus ascended into Heaven from Bethany's launching pad...
- God sent the Holy Spirit to live in each believer...

- The work of the believer is to evangelize the world...
- Jesus is coming again...
- There will be a judgment for all who reject this message...

His message is one that cannot be successfully challenged! His message and our message, is an unchallengeable message!

III. AN UNQUESTIONABLE LOVE...

It is true that Jesus has gone back into Heaven, but he left us an unquestionable love! [John 3:16-18](#) (NKJV)

“For God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son, that whoever believes in Him should not perish but have everlasting life. ¹⁷“For God did not send His Son into the world to condemn the world, but that the world through Him might be saved. ¹⁸“He who believes in Him is not condemned; but he who does not believe is condemned already, because he has not believed in the name of the only begotten Son of God.”

How in the world would one question the love exhibited by Jesus Christ? Probably the greatest affront to God would be to question His love and His Sons love for us in light of what they were willing to do in order to establish a relationship with us!

God allowed His son to become the sacrifice for sin and Jesus: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Left His home so we might have an eternal one...

- Gave His life that we might live forever...
- Was bruised for our iniquities...
- Was chastised so we could have peace...
- Gave His body for our healing...
- Shed His blood for our redemption...
- Carried our sins so we might be free from sin...
- Showed us his love unreservedly...
- Provided his love unequivocally...
- Gave us his love unconditionally...

I ask us the following questions concerning the love of God:

- Did he ask us if we love Him before He loved us?
- Did He ask us if we needed forgiveness before He provided a path for forgiveness?
- Did He require our all before He gave His all?
- Did He ask us if we needed hope before He provided hope?
- Did He ask if we needed healing before He provided a cure for all diseases?
- Did He ask us if we needed life before He provided abundant life?

Does anyone here want to question the love of God?

Fredrick M. Lehman wrote the words to one of the greatest songs ever to be written about the love of God in 1917 in Pasadena, California. The words to this song were published in *"Songs That Are Different"*, Volume 2, 1919. The lyrics are based on the Jewish poem *"Haddamut"*, written in Aramaic in 1050 by

Meir Ben Isaac Nehorai, a cantor in Worms, Germany;
they have been translated into at least 18 languages.
Listen to the words, *“The love of God is greater far
Than tongue or pen can ever tell; It goes beyond the
highest star, And reaches to the lowest hell; The guilty
pair, bowed down with care, God gave His Son to win;
His erring child He reconciled, And pardoned from his
sin.*

*O love of God, how rich and pure!
How measureless and strong!
It shall forevermore endure
The saints’ and angels’ song.*

*When years of time shall pass away, And earthly
thrones and kingdoms fall, When men, who here refuse
to pray, On rocks and hills and mountains call, God’s
love so sure, shall still endure, All measureless and
strong; Redeeming grace to Adam’s race— The saints’
and angels’ song.*

*O love of God, how rich and pure!
How measureless and strong!
It shall forevermore endure
The saints’ and angels’ song.*

*Could we with ink the ocean fill, And were the skies of
parchment made, Were every stalk on earth a quill,
And every man a scribe by trade, To write the love of
God above, Would drain the ocean dry. Nor could the
scroll contain the whole,
Though stretched from sky to sky.*

*O love of God, how rich and pure!
How measureless and strong!
It shall forevermore endure
The saints' and angels' song."*

I submit to you, **the love of God is unquestionable!**
(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)

IV. AN UNMERITED GRACE...

The word grace is mentioned one hundred seventy times in the King James Version of the Bible. This is a very, very, important subject!

When it comes to the grace of God, we can: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Sing about it and never understand it...
- Discuss it and never exhaust it...
- Debate it and never fully comprehend it...
- Receive it and never fully grasp it...
- Display it and never really have a handle on it...
- Ignore it and never outrun it...

The greatest gift available to mankind is the grace of God!

Throughout the Old Testament grace was rarely seen, Law was in effect! This is because man chose for it to be that way. Through a stubborn refusal to do things Gods way, man chose by an act of His own will to live by Law and not by grace!

Jesus came to this earth to bring about a new dispensation which would become known as grace!

Jesus lived thirty three and a half years but until He left earth bound for Glory, grace was just a rumor! Until Christ finished His work on the cross grace was only something which was a figment of man's wildest imagination! **Though Jesus is gone, grace remains!**
(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)

Jesus ascended to the Father to become the administrator of grace! Hebrews 7:19-28 (KJV) ***"For the law made nothing perfect, but the bringing in of a better hope did; by the which we draw nigh unto God. ²⁰And inasmuch as not without an oath he was made priest: ²¹(For those priests were made without an oath; but this with an oath by him that said unto him, The Lord sware and will not repent, Thou art a priest for ever after the order of Melchisedec:) ²²By so much was Jesus made a surety of a better testament. ²³And they truly were many priests, because they were not suffered to continue by reason of death: ²⁴But this man, because he continueth ever, hath an unchangeable priesthood. ²⁵Wherefore he is able also to save them to the uttermost that come unto God by him, seeing he ever liveth to make intercession for them. ²⁶For such an high priest became us, who is holy, harmless, undefiled, separate from sinners, and made higher than the heavens; ²⁷Who needeth not daily, as those high priests, to offer up sacrifice, first for his own sins, and then for the people's: for this he did once, when he offered up himself. ²⁸For the law maketh men high priests which have infirmity; but the word of the oath, which was since the law, maketh the Son, who is consecrated for evermore."***
Jesus is seated at the right hand of God, doing one

thing, administrating grace in your life and in mine!
W-O-W!

Think of grace in this way: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Grace covers me when I deserve it the least...
- Grace releases me from my fiercest bondages...
- Grace opens up doors for me which was permanently shut...
- Grace provides a way of escaping judgment...
- Grace intervenes when sin is present...
- Grace delivers when the enemy persists...
- Grace proves my faith and salvation...
- Grace allows me the chance at heaven...

In our culture we are conditioned to believe “*You get what you pay for.*” The thing about grace is:

(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- We cannot earn it...
- We cannot purchase it...
- We cannot be good enough to deserve it...
- We cannot work hard enough to be worthy of it...
- We cannot be acquainted with enough people to negotiate it...

Grace is a gift which Jesus left behind for us, and He is now administrating it in our lives!

How do we receive this grace? Ephesians 2:8 (NKJV)
“For by grace you have been saved through faith,

and that not of yourselves; it is the gift of God, ⁹not of works, lest anyone should boast.”

We receive grace by accepting it as a gift!

The Scripture tells us it is possible to frustrate the grace of God! Galatians 2:20-21 (KJV) *“I am crucified with Christ: nevertheless I live; yet not I, but Christ liveth in me: and the life which I now live in the flesh I live by the faith of the Son of God, who loved me, and gave himself for me. ²¹I do not frustrate the grace of God: for if righteousness come by the law, then Christ is dead in vain.”* If grace is a gift from God, how could one frustrate this gift? The grace of God is frustrated if we: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Add to it...
- Restrict it...
- Take away from it...
- Delineate from its power...
- Relegate it to an inferior position...

I am not capable of describing grace! The only words I know which come closest to describing grace are:

- Amazing...
- Beyond belief...
- Continual...
- Deep...
- Endless...
- Fathomless...
- Great...
- Huge...

- Immeasurable...
- Jesus...
- Keen...
- Lavish...
- Marvelous...
- Non-negotiable...
- Outstanding...
- Profound...
- Quantitious...
- Remarkable...
- Splendid...
- Tremendous...
- Unfathomable...
- Vast...
- Wonderful...
- Extraordinary...

Think of this; Jesus left this grace for us! It belongs to us! It is here for us!

The only question which remains is whether we will accept it or reject it?

V. AN UNSTOPPABLE FORCE...

The next to the last words Jesus ever spoke to His disciples are recorded in Luke 24:46-49 (NKJV)

“Then He said to them, **“Thus it is written, and thus it was necessary for the Christ to suffer and to rise from the dead the third day, ⁴⁷“and that repentance and remission of sins should be preached in His name to all nations, beginning at Jerusalem. ⁴⁸“And you are witnesses of these things. ⁴⁹“Behold, I send**

the Promise of My Father upon you; but tarry in the city of Jerusalem until you are endued with power from on high.”

Acts 1:8 (NKJV) *“But you shall receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you; and you shall be witnesses to Me in Jerusalem, and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth.”*

It is a fact that Jesus is gone, but He left adequate power for His disciples to do His work and make a difference in the world.

Too many today: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Minimize the importance of the power of God...
- Think the power of God is optional equipment... (I wonder how many of the folks who treat the power of God as optional equipment would agree that a good education is optional to the success of their children)
- Overlook what the power of God is capable of...
- Overestimate the ability of personal power against the enemy of sin...
- Miscalculate the need for the power of God in reaching a world that has lost its direction...

I cannot stress it enough; we need the power of God in our lives for many reasons: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- To give us power over sin...
- To help us live holy in a sinful culture...

- To assist us in developing strategies to reach the lost...
- To cause us to become personal witnesses to those in our circle of influence...
- To motivate us to fulfill the great commission of the Lord Jesus, to take this Gospel to the ends of the earth...

If we did not need power, Jesus would not have furnished it for us! Listen to His words concerning His desire to make power available to His church.

John 16:7 (KJV) ***"I tell you the truth; It is expedient for you that I go away: for if I go not away, the Comforter will not come unto you; but if I depart, I will send him unto you."*** When Dr. Thomas Trask was the General Superintendent of the Assemblies of God the chairman of the Southern Baptist Convention told him, *"Whatever you do, cling to your distinctiveness, don't change who you are."* Some of our own ministers are running as fast and far as they can from the power of God!

The Power that Jesus wanted to gift to His disciples was a power that would strengthen each of them personally and cause them to have an ability to reach their world with the Gospel of Christ!

Before Pentecost the first century disciples were a group of witless, spineless, gutless wonders who could not even stand their ground when Jesus needed them the most; on the night of His crucifixion! Peter's denial of Christ on that fateful evening is known worldwide, but little is known about the actions of the

other disciples! Matthew 26:50-56 (KJV) *“Then came they, and laid hands on Jesus, and took him. ⁵¹And, behold, one of them which were with Jesus stretched out his hand, and drew his sword, and struck a servant of the high priest’s, and smote off his ear.*

*⁵²Then said Jesus unto him, **Put up again thy sword into his place: for all they that take the sword shall perish with the sword.** ⁵³Thinkest thou that I cannot now pray to my Father, and he shall presently give me more than twelve legions of angels? ⁵⁴But how then shall the scriptures be fulfilled, that thus it must be? ⁵⁵In that same hour said Jesus to the multitudes, **Are ye come out as against a thief with swords and staves for to take me? I sat daily with you teaching in the temple, and ye laid no hold on me.** ⁵⁶But all this was done, that the scriptures of the prophets might be fulfilled. Then all the disciples forsook him, and fled.”*

After Judas rejected Christ and the disciples forsook Him on the night of the crucifixion, Pentecost occurred and not one other disciple ever turned his back on Christ! Their stick-ability was not a result of the path being easy, in fact they faced great difficulty, even death, but they did not give up!

- Andrew died on the cross.
- Simon was crucified.
- Bartholomew was flayed alive.
- James the son of Zebedee was beheaded.
- James the son of Alphaeus was beaten to death.
- Thomas was run through with a lance.
- Mathias was stoned and then beheaded.
- Matthew was slain by the sword.

- Peter was crucified upside down.
- Thaddeus was shot to death with arrows.
- Philip was hanged.
- Only John made it through alive but he was exiled to a small island in the middle of the Mediterranean Sea.

Notice what happened after Pentecost:

- 3,000 saved the first day... (Acts 2:37-38)
- God added to the church daily such as should be saved... (Acts 2:47)
- 2,000 are saved at Solomon's Porch... (Acts 3:1-4)
- The Samaritans become Christians... (Acts 8:1-12)
- Men and women were baptized following their conversion... (Acts 8:12-13)
- The Ethiopian eunuch is converted... (Acts 8:36-39)
- Saul (Paul) receives Christ... (Acts 9:18)
- The household of Cornelius becomes Christians... (Acts 10:43)
- The people of Antioch are converted... (Acts 11:19-21)
- Sergius Paulus becomes a Christian... (Acts 13:4-12)
- Many Jews and religious proselytes follow Paul and Barnabas at Antioch... (Acts 13:13-48)
- A great multitude of individuals follow Christ at Iconium... (Acts 14:1)

- An undetermined number of people make decisions for Christ at Lystra and Derbe... (Acts 14)
- The Philippian jailer and his family become followers of Christ... (Acts 16)
- Lydia comes to faith in Christ... (Acts 16)
- A great multitude of the Greeks and many of the leading women join themselves to the faith at Thessalonica... (Acts 17:1-12)
- The conversion of the Athenians at Mars Hill... (Acts 17:16-34)
- Many Corinthian people are converted... (Acts 18:8)
- At Corinth Aquila and Pricilla follow Jesus... (Acts 18:24-28)
- The twelve disciples of John the Baptist are converted... (Acts 19:1-10)

This power is an unstoppable force and it is available to EVERY believer! Acts 4:13 (NKJV) ***“Now when they saw the boldness of Peter and John, and perceived that they were uneducated and untrained men, they marveled. And they realized that they had been with Jesus.”*** Acts 4:31 (NKJV) ***“And when they had prayed, the place where they were assembled together was shaken; and they were all filled with the Holy Spirit, and they spoke the word of God with boldness.”***

Because of the power Jesus furnished to **the first century disciples**, they **were unstoppable!** **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- False doctrine could not stop them...
- Roman laws and leaders could not stop them...
- Jewish traditions could not stop them...
- Conflict could not stop them...
- Persecution could not stop them...
- The threat of death could not stop them...

This generation of Pentecostal's needs to reacquaint itself with power of God! **(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)**

The first century church had it, nothing has changed, and today's church can have it as well!

I am afraid the church of the twenty first century is in danger of walking away from the power Jesus left behind! If we are going to be everything Jesus intended us to be we will need to be reconnected to the source of power which Jesus left behind!

VI. AN UNFAILING PROMISE...

I Thessalonians 4:16-18 (NKJV) ***"For the Lord Himself will descend from heaven with a shout, with the voice of an archangel, and with the trumpet of God. And the dead in Christ will rise first. ¹⁷Then we who are alive and remain shall be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air. And thus we shall always be with the Lord.***

¹⁸***Therefore comfort one another with these words."*** I Corinthians 15:51-58 (NKJV) ***"Behold, I tell you a mystery: We shall not all sleep, but we shall all be changed— ⁵²in a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trumpet. For the trumpet will sound, and***

the dead will be raised incorruptible, and we shall be changed. ⁵³For this corruptible must put on incorruption, and this mortal must put on immortality. ⁵⁴So when this corruptible has put on incorruption, and this mortal has put on immortality, then shall be brought to pass the saying that is written: “Death is swallowed up in victory.” ⁵⁵ “O Death, where is your sting? O Hades, where is your victory?” ⁵⁶The sting of death is sin, and the strength of sin is the law. ⁵⁷But thanks be to God, who gives us the victory through our Lord Jesus Christ. ⁵⁸Therefore, my beloved brethren, be steadfast, immovable, always abounding in the work of the Lord, knowing that your labor is not in vain in the Lord.”

ILLUSTRATION:

Reverend Boudreaux was the part-time pastor of the local Cajun Baptist Church and Pastor Thibodaux was the minister of the Covenant Church across the road.

They were both standing by the road, pounding a sign into the ground, that read: 'Da End is Near

Turn Yo Sef 'Roun Now Afore It Be Too Late!'

As a car sped past them, the driver leaned out his window and yelled, 'You religious nuts!'

From the curve they heard screeching tires, and a big splash...

Boudreaux turns to Thibodaux and asks, 'Do ya tink maybe da sign should jussay.....'Bridge Out?'

ILLUSTRATION:

One of the great heroes of American history is a man who was born and raised in Little Rock, Arkansas; his name is General Douglas McArthur. During World War II, his leadership ability came to the forefront as he was placed in charge of the South Pacific Theatre and was stationed in the Philippines.

During the later days of the war, General McArthur's men had taken a beating so he withdrew them and moved them to Australia to recover. As he boarded the DC 9 in the Philippine it was obvious to General McArthur that the Philippine population was anxious about their future.

*Standing there noticing the fear and anxiousness on the faces of the Philippine people he spoke three words that have been immortalized in American history, **"I shall return!"***

Several months of war continued but one day the Philippine skies were filled with the hum of military planes as General McArthur made good on his promise to return to the Philippines!

A little over 2,000 years ago, Jesus stood on a mountain over-looking that wonderful city Jerusalem and said to his beloved disciples, John 14:1-3 (NKJV)
"Let not your heart be troubled; you believe in God, believe also in Me. ²"In My Father's house are many

mansions; if it were not so, I would have told you. I go to prepare a place for you. ³*“And if I go and prepare a place for you, I will come again and receive you to Myself; that where I am, there you may be also.”*

(PANORAMA OF PROPHECY) (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

Sure things get tough at times:

- The body hurts...
- The spirit becomes weak...
- The mind is conflicted...
- The pain persists...
- The trauma continues...
- The worries never seem to end...
- The vision becomes faint...
- The path becomes darkened with care...

Take heart weary pilgrim, Jesus left a promise to
“Come again!”

We cannot afford to: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Quit...
- Give up...
- Become discouraged...
- Think of turning back...

We must hold to Gods unchanging hand! His promises are absolutely accurate! He is coming again!

He did not leave us comfortless but He provides everything we need to make it through whatever we are called upon to endure!

ILLUSTRATION:

“The Wonderful Window.”

A London clerk worked in a run-down, drab, depressing, part of the city. This clerk refused to allow his outlook to determine his happiness so one day he bought a picture with an inspiring scene and installed it in the window of his office that overlooked the worst part of the city. The picture was of beautiful castles and towers, green rolling hills, beautiful parks and lovely homes. In the picture a Knight rode a stallion through the streets and watched over the people with pride.

As the clerk worked long hours at the tedious task of making everything balance he felt as though he was working for the Knight in the picture. This produced a sense of honor, dignity, and hope. As he looked at the picture of what could be rather than looking at what is, the picture changed his life!”

We need not allow our circumstances or surroundings to discourage us! **God has placed us where we are but He assured us He would “Come again!”**

(PLAY RAPTURE VIDEO)

We need to quit looking at the drab scenes, and look at the promises He left us!

